

硯台

Teaching Taste to an Agent

INK PAINTING PROMPTS FROM CLASSICAL VERSE

Augustin Chan · HKWD Meetup · August 2026



Where I wandered, after I didn't find anything in the I-Ching section



| Augustin Chan

How do we build AI that expands what people can do — without quietly taking away their judgment?

Culture, Research, Surgical Software — three answers to that one question.

sixlines.online — the app behind this talk

Co-host, hongkongaipodcast.com

Connect on [LinkedIn](#)



linktr.ee/augchan42

The I-Ching · 易經

Six bits. Sixty-four states.

$$2^1 = 2$$

ONE LINE



$$2^3 = 8$$

TRIGRAMS



$$2^6 = 64$$

HEXAGRAMS



That is the I-Ching.

One of sixty-four

Upper image plus lower image.



艮 Mountain



坎 Water

蒙 · Youthful Folly

A reading is a move

Some lines change. You get a second hexagram.

present · 48



井 Jing · The Well



CHANGING LINES

relating · 59

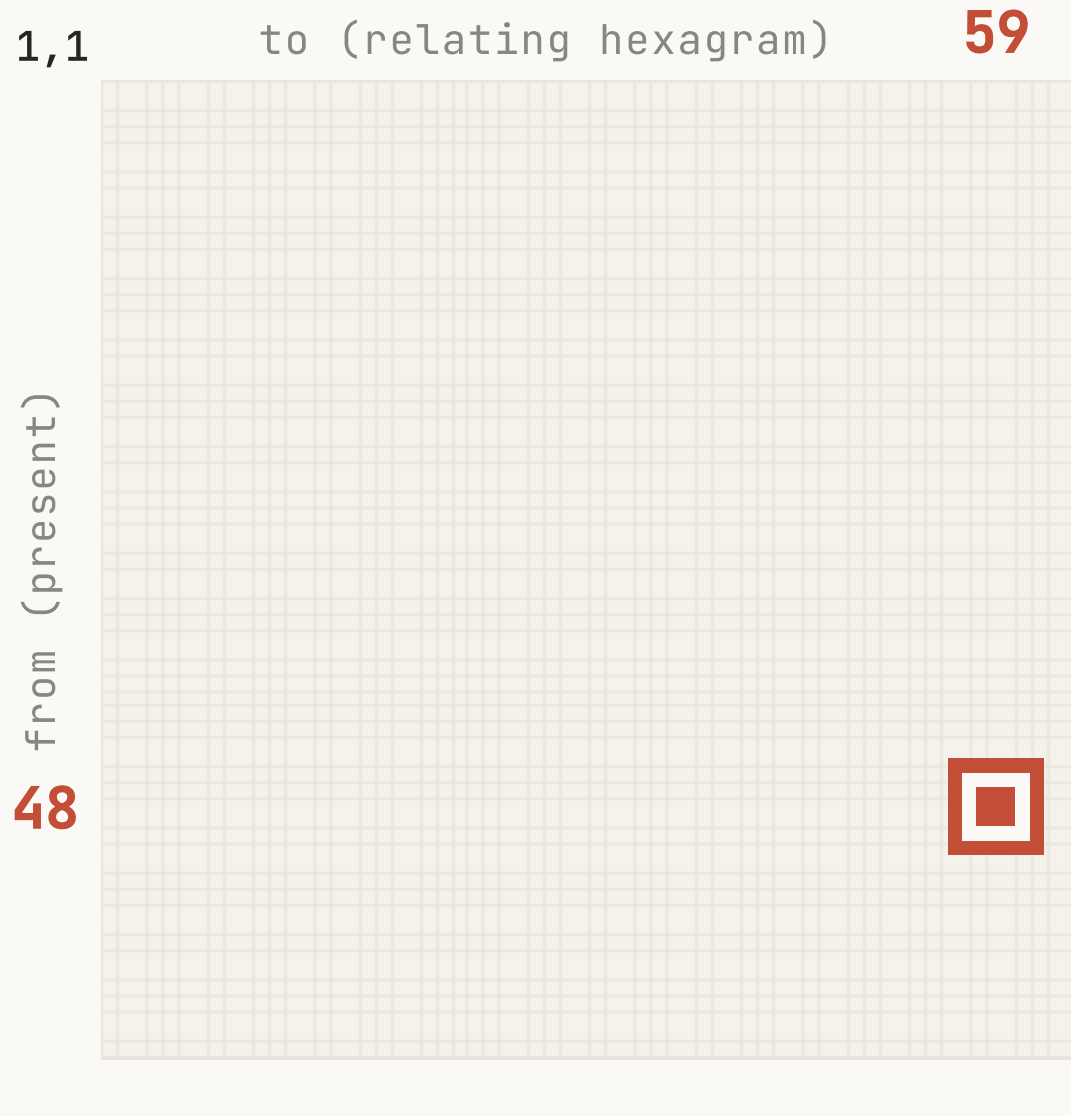


渙 Huan · Dispersion

LOOKUP KEY

48-59

one cell, one verse,
one painting



Every pair gets a poem

焦氏易林 Jiaoshi Yilin — a Western Han table. A verse in every cell.

$$64 \times 64 = 4,096$$

COMPLETE TRANSITION TABLE

Row = present hexagram.

Column = future hexagram.

paintings[from][to]

48 井 The Well → 59 涣 Dispersion

The cell comes from a coin toss — never from your history.

4,096 original ink brush artworks



焦氏易林·家人
Jiao's Forest of Changes

天命赤鳥，與君徼期。征伐无道，誅其君傲，居止何憂？

Heaven commands the red bird, setting the appointed time with the lord. He campaigns against the lawless, executing their arrogant ruler. Where he dwells and rests, what worry is there?

Active Line 0



Today



Dates



Ask



Journal



Settings

The Challenge

Generate 4,096 unique ink paintings — one for every cell.

4,096

VERSES

64×64

HEXAGRAM PAIRS

c. 40 BC

JIAOSHI YILIN · WESTERN HAN

Built for **SixLines.online** — I-Ching reference & Chinese almanac





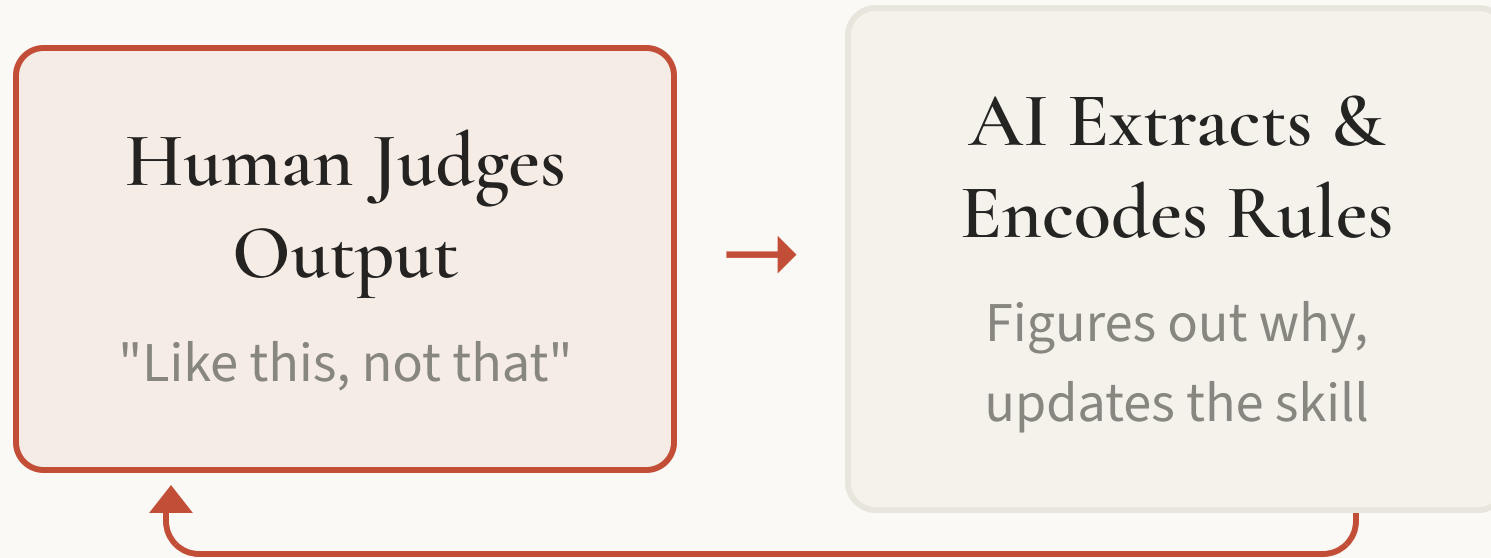
THESIS

What Is Taste?

Taste is the essence of what you like, but hard to explain in words. A person's taste is usually best defined through prolonged observation.

How do you teach something you can only recognize — never fully articulate — to a machine?

The Iterative Loop



Re-run. Judge again. Repeat.

You can't reason about the model. You can only judge its output.

Not All Verses Paint Pictures

18.6%

RICH IMAGERY

霜降閉戶，熟出隱處
不見日月，與死爲伍

*Frost falls, doors seal shut.
Hidden from sun and moon,
dwelling with death.*

50.0%

NEEDS EXPANSION

跛躓未起，失利後市
不得鹿子

*Stumbling, not yet risen.
Missed the market — the fawn
escapes.*

31.4%

ABSTRACT / NO IMAGERY

元吉无咎，安寧不殆

*Great fortune, no blame.
Peace without peril.*

Round 1: Style as Suffix

"...overflowing well, water branching... Ink wash with soft watercolor tints."



The model treated "ink wash" as a filter, not a language.

Round 2: Try a Different Style?

"...overflowing well... Wabi-sabi aesthetic, muted tones."



It's a photograph. The style suffix changed the medium.

CORE DISCOVERY

Style Is Not a Suffix

Write it like the *caption under the painting* — not a scene plus a style suffix.

Bad — style as suffix

"A tree on a hill. Chinese ink painting style."

Good — painterly language embedded in the scene

"A gnarled pine leans from a cliff face like a brushstroke frozen mid-sweep, roots gripping stone above a gorge filled with morning mist. Chinese ink painting."

Same verse. First time it worked.



An overflowing well sends water spilling in four branching streams across barren hillside, carving shallow channels in the earth. **Foreground**, the well mouth brims over, water sheeting across worn stone. **Midground**, the streams diverge eastward, spreading thin over sun-baked ground, nourishing sparse grasses. **Beyond**, desolate brown hills roll to a hazy horizon, the water lost among them. Amber reflections glint where the shallow streams catch the last daylight. **Chinese ink painting.**

What the AI Analyzed

The human said “this works.” The AI figured out *why*. Four of the seven rules came out of that analysis.

Painterly words produce paintings **RULE 7**

Language register controls the medium. Photographic words produce photographs.

Force depth **RULE 2**

Foreground/midground/background forces the model to compose, not just fill.

Warm accent **RULE 4**

A single point of color in monochrome gives the eye a destination.

Frame the scene **RULE 1**

Gates, tree canopies, gorge walls — never a subject floating in open space.



Rules 1, 2, 4 and 7 — visible in one image

What the Human Kept

The AI distilled these from human preferences:

7 Composition Rules

1. Frame the scene
2. Force depth
3. Demand contrast
4. Warm accent
5. Favor diagonals
6. Discoverable detail
7. Painterly language

Plus a disambiguation table. Write crane bird — plain crane renders a machine.

5 Style Categories

- **atmospheric-night**
darkness, isolation, winter, grief
- **ink-landscape**
nature, water, seasons, travel
- **figures-in-mist**
narrative, ceremony, human emotion
- **bold-action**
animals, combat, storms, struggle
- **cosmic-night**
stars, heaven, myth, immortals

AI reads verse tone → selects palette.



◦ atmospheric-night

明滅光息，不能復食
精魄既喪，以夜為室

*Light dims, radiance dies. Night
becomes one's dwelling.*

噬嗑 → 頤 · hexagram 21 → 27



- ink-landscape

禹鑿龍門，通利水源
東注滄海，民得安存

*Yu carved Dragon Gate and opened the
water's source.*

*Flowing east to the vast sea, the
people found safe dwelling.*

乾 → 豫 • hexagram 1 → 16



• figures-in-mist

雨師娶婦，黃岩季子
成禮既婚，相呼面南
膏澤應時，年豐大喜

*The Rain Master takes a bride — the
youngest daughter of Huangyan.
Rites completed, they turn to face
south.*

*Timely rain and rich moisture; a
bountiful year, great rejoicing.*

損 → 益 • hexagram 41 → 42



- bold-action

白龍黑虎，起伏俱怒
蚩尤敗走，死於魯首

*White dragon and black tiger rise in
shared fury.*

*Chi You flees in defeat, slain at Lu
Shou.*

益 → 比 • hexagram 42 → 8



◦ cosmic-night

龍生馬淵，壽考且神
飛騰上天，舍宿軒轅

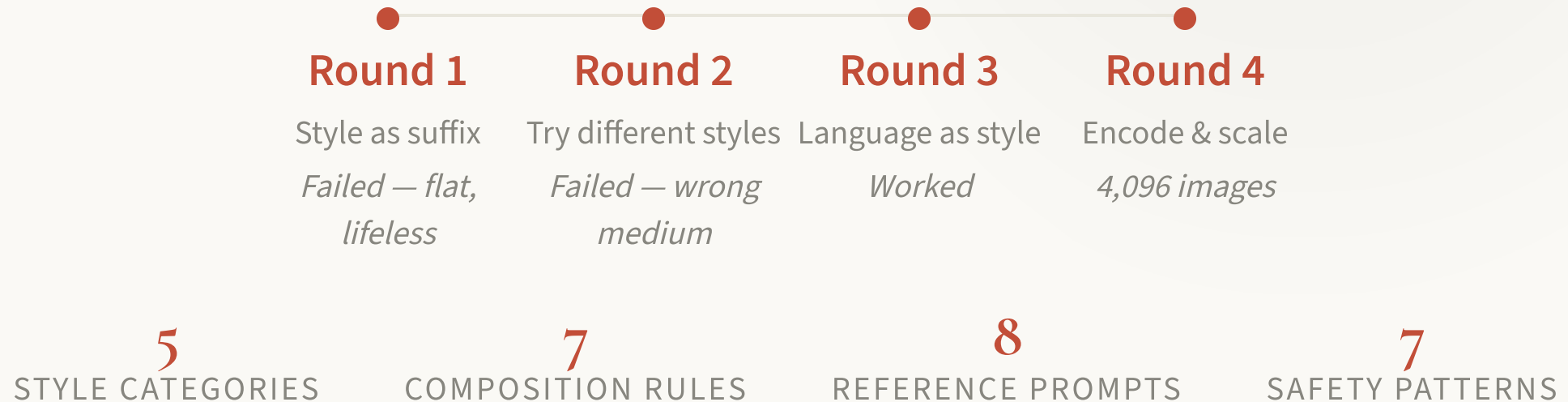
*The dragon born in the deep pool,
long-lived and divine.*

*Flying upward to heaven, dwelling
among the stars of Xuanyuan.*

未濟 → 歸妹 · hexagram 64 → 54

Four Rounds to a Skill

Each round encoded more taste:



Running It 4,096 Times

Nobody eyeballs four thousand images.

52

REJECTED OUTRIGHT

Content filters refused the prompt. Substitution renders the verse through its setting and aftermath rather than its action — a more structured route from text to image.

HTTP 200

SAVED ANYWAY

14–31 rendered as a black square. Valid 1024×1024 WebP, correct header, 200 response. The model refused; the pipeline wrote the refusal frame to disk. A reader found it.

entropy < 2.0

REJECTED BEFORE UPLOAD

Shannon entropy over the histogram. A solid color scores exactly zero, real paintings above four. Nothing near-uniform uploads.

The skill already had the rule. Those prompts predated it.

Naked and chasing a fox. Two of people bound. One of a white tiger. All are categories the skill's Content Safety section names.

When the Verse Has No Image

31% of verses carry no concrete imagery.

Verse (input)

元吉无咎，安寧不殆

比 → 明夷 · "Great fortune, no blame. Peace without peril."



key 8-36 · ink-landscape · 52 words

What the skill tells the agent

```
# Style table fallback for abstract verses:  
If abstract, choose by tone:  
    ominous    → atmospheric-night  
    auspicious → ink-landscape / figures-in-mist  
    mixed      → bold-action  
  
# All 7 composition rules still apply.
```

Agent output

Tone: serene, auspicious → **ink-landscape**

Frame: valley at sunset, stone steps through a temple gate

Depth: worn steps (fg) → wanderer on path (mid) → hazy peaks (bg)

Accent: golden-hour light on the gate

The rules require concrete visual elements even when the verse supplies none.

What Is a Skill?

```
---
name: verse-to-prompt
description: Convert classical Chinese verses into ink
painting
  image generation prompts.
user-invocable: true
argument-hint: [paste your verse here]
---

# Verse → Ink Painting Prompt

Given a verse, produce:
1. A style classification with rationale
2. A 50-60 word English prompt ending "Chinese ink painting."
3. A faithful English translation

## The 7 Composition Rules (MANDATORY)
...
```

A **SKILL.md** file — YAML frontmatter plus instructions. No runtime code, no weights. Just text you can open and read.

Skills ship inside **plugins**. You install the plugin; its skills come with it.

inkstone/ the plugin

- └ **verse-to-prompt** this one
- └ image-to-scene
- └ create-explanation
- └ ...

github.com/augchan42/inkstone

Takeaways

Style is not a suffix

Language register controls the medium. Painterly words produce paintings; appending "ink painting style" produces a filter.

Taste is iterative, not declarative

You can't define good output upfront. It emerges through cycles of human judgment and AI analysis.

Humans judge; the AI articulates

You say "this one." The AI figures out why it works and writes the rule down — where you can check it.

Encode the preference, not the person.

A bookshop that only knew what I told it. A file that only knows what I told it.

硯台

多謝 · Thank You

Questions?

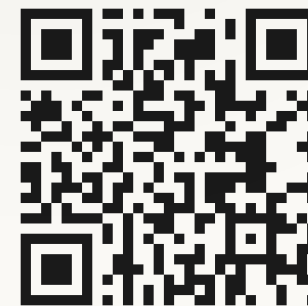


These slides

App: sixlines.online 🍏 🤖

Plugin: github.com/augchan42/inkstone

Everything else: linktr.ee/augchan42



linktr.ee/augchan42